

MANNING ZHANG

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EDUCATION

Expected in Aug. 2027	Joint Ph.D. in Social Policy and Sociology, <i>Brandeis University</i> , Waltham, MA
May 2023	M.A. , Social Policy, <i>Brandeis University</i> , Waltham, MA
Jun. 2020	B.L. ¹ , Sociology, <i>Fudan University</i> , Shanghai, China
	Bachelor's Thesis: <i>Chinese Farmer's Identity and Land Consciousness in an Urbanizing Era</i> Advisors: Yi Zhou, Ronggui Huang
Jun. 2020	Minor Certificate , French Language, <i>Shanghai International Studies University</i> Shanghai, China

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Health Governance; Medical Sociology; Sociology of Culture; Sociology of Knowledge; Science and Technology Studies; Health Policy; Fitness.

PUBLICATIONS

Academic Publication

Expected 2027	Zhang, Manning (2027). Re-politicize Health: Intersected Inequities in Health Knowledge Production and Application. <i>Sociology of Health & Illness</i> . (In submission)
Expected 2027	Zhang, Manning . (2027). Centralizing lifestyle in status-making. <i>Sociological Inquiry</i> . (In submission)
2026	Ressler, Robert & Zhang, Manning & Leonardos, Madeline & Noelke, Clemens & Acevedo-Garcia, Dolores. (2026). Structural Racism, Neighborhood Opportunity, and Racial/Ethnic Disparities in Homicide Risk, <i>JAMA Network Open</i> . (In submission, preprint available online)
2026	Haque, Zora & Zhang, Manning ² & Meschede, Tatjana & Warfield, Marji. (2026). Undoing the STEM/non-STEM Boundary: Exploring Women's STEM-Related Experiences and Binary Definitions of STEM Involvement, <i>Gender, Work & Organization</i> .
2025	Zhang, Manning (2025). Gamification of Fitness and Training in Jacob Bustad and Gashaw Abeza (Eds.), <i>Technology, Sport and Recreation: Physical Activity in the Digital Age</i> . Routledge.

¹ B.L.: Bachelor of Laws; in China's disciplinary classification, sociology falls under the Law category.

² The article is co-first-authored.

- 2025 **Zhang, Manning & Ressler, Robert & Noelke, Clemens & Acevedo-Garcia, Dolores.** (2025). Disparities in Violent Deaths by Neighborhood Opportunity with the Child Opportunity Index 3.0, Preliminary Results, *AJPM Focus*.
- 2024 **Zhang, Manning.** (2024). “Book Review: The Quest for Sexual Health: How an Elusive Ideal Has Transformed Science, Politics, and Everyday Life.” *Sexualities*.
- 2021 Ma, Ruofan & **Zhang, Manning & Oakman, Jonathan & Wang, Jiping & Zhu, Ziqi & Zhao, Chendi & Hu, Zhiyuan & Buchanan, Nicole.** (2021). Eating disorders treatment experiences and social support: Perspectives from service seekers in mainland China. *International Journal of Eating Disorders*.
- 2021 Ma, Ruofan & Oakman, Jonathan & **Zhang, Manning & Zhang, Xianni & Chen, Wei & Buchanan, Nicole.** (2021). Lessons for mental health systems from the COVID-19 frontline: Chinese healthcare workers’ challenges, resources, resilience, and cultural considerations. *Traumatology*.

Selected Public Writing

- 2026 Xie, Qiuyi, **Zhang, Manning.** (2026, September 15). Early-Stage Financing for Hard-Tech Startups in the Yangtze River Delta: Direct Investment by State-Owned Capital Becomes a Trend, While Cross-Provincial Collaboration Gains Momentum. *ThePaper.cn* (澎湃新闻研究所).
https://m.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_34066468 (In Mandarin)
- 2025 **Zhang, Manning.** (2025, June 10). Interview with Musa al-Gharbi. *ASA Culture Section Newsletter*. <https://asaculturesection.org/2025/06/10/interview-with-musa-al-gharbi/> (Other interviews are available on the culture newsletter website).
- 2024 **Zhang, Manning.** (2024, December 11). What Is the Boundary of Global Health? *Open-Air Journal*. <https://openairjournal.substack.com/p/what-is-the-boundary-of-global-health?r=1ez6az>
- 2024 **Zhang, Manning.** (2024, April 30). Climate change and green gentrification. *Open-Air Journal*. <https://openairjournal.substack.com/p/climate-change-and-green-gentrification>

WORK IN PROGRESS

Manning Zhang. “Fitness as a Temporal Craft: A Two-Wave Interview Study of Exercise in Early Adulthood.” (Submitted for paper competition; to be submitted to *Leisure Studies*).

Time and the body are central to fitness, yet the sociology of sport has rarely theorized fitness as a temporal practice. This study draws on carnal sociology and sociological theories of time to treat fitness as a temporal craft: the deliberate shaping of bodily capacity generates and sustains particular temporalities. Through two-wave interviews with thirteen university students, first in their final undergraduate year and again after graduation, it examines how fitness mediates the transition to adulthood. The analysis identifies three layered moves through which this craft is practiced: (1) young adults recalibrate the aim and move from an aspirational temporality centered on transformation to a defensive temporality centered on maintenance; (2) they recompose rhythm when they replace the institutionalized schedules of university life with self-managed ones after that scaffolding collapses; (3) they also repair rupture and protect routines through pause, lowered bars, and the rescheduling of missed sessions. These moves align with scholarship on time work and reflexive body techniques, showing how young adults reauthor exercise amid temporal uncertainty and sustain biographical continuity through a practice

in which their identity is embedded. In this way, the paper places embodied fitness practice at the center of social theories of time and bridges the sociologies of time and sport through this three-move framework that reads fitness as an everyday technology of livable temporality.

Manning Zhang. “Building Community Through Fitness: The YMCA and the Social Life of Exercise.”

This paper draws on interviews with 23 YMCA members from diverse immigration, racial/ethnic, gender, and socioeconomic backgrounds, as well as ethnographic observations at 13 YMCA branches in Greater Boston. I also draw on historical materials from YMCA archives to examine how fitness practices contribute to community-making. By connecting contemporary experiences of exercise with the YMCA’s longstanding institutional mission, the study shows how physical activity can foster social ties, cultivate belonging, and sustain civic engagement amid broader processes of social fragmentation.

Manning Zhang. “Making Sense of Fitness and Health: Young Adults’ Understandings of Well-Being in Campus Recreation Spaces.”

This paper investigates how young adults aged 18-30 define and relate the concepts of fitness and health in their everyday lives. Drawing on ethnographic interviews, it examines how participants navigate competing cultural narratives about appearance, performance, self-care, and wellness, revealing the diverse meanings they attach to being both “fit” and “healthy.”

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

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| 2026 | “The Politics of Health Knowledge Production: Intersectional Inequities and Obesity Governance in China” British Sociological Association Medical Sociology Group Annual Conference , Newcastle Upon Tyne, England, September. |
| 2026 | “Centralizing lifestyle in status-making” Accepted for the American Sociological Association Annual Conference , New York City, NY, August. |
| 2025 | “Re-politicize Health: Intersected Inequities in Health Knowledge Production and Application” American Sociological Association Annual Conference , Chicago, IL, August.
* Conference abstract “Centralizing lifestyle in status-making” was accepted for the ASA Culture Section Roundtables. |
| 2024 | “Not by Accident: The Technological Production of Embodied Health Inequalities” and “Undoing the STEM/non-STEM boundary: Exploring Women’s STEM-Related Experiences and Binary Definitions of STEM Involvement,” American Sociological Association Annual Conference and The Society for the Study of Social Problems Annual Meeting , Montréal, Canada, August
* Conference abstract “Unveiling the Impact of Bike Infrastructure on Urban Neighborhood Transformation in the Greater Boston Area” was accepted for the ASA Community/Urban Sociology Roundtables. |
| 2024 | “Status: a hierarchy of honor” and “Understanding Health Technology and Inequality” (in Mandarin), Chinese Sociological Association Annual Conference , Harbin, China, July. |
| 2024 | “‘There is more than one voice’: A Qualitative Study of State and Civil Discourses Regarding China’s Rural Land Reform.” Accepted for the 86th Annual Meeting of the Rural Sociological Society , Madison, WI, July. |

- 2024 “Unveiling the Impact of Bike Infrastructure on Urban Neighborhood Transformation in the Greater Boston Area.” **Boston Area Research Initiative (BARI) Conference 2024: Greater Boston’s Annual Insight-to-Impact Summit**, Boston, MA, April.
- 2024 “Boston moving: fitness clubs and community-making practices.” **American Sociological Association Community and Urban Sociology Section Virtual Mini-Conference: Building Communities in Research and Practice**, virtual, April.
- 2024 “Tackling the Bamboo Ceiling: Experience of Early-stage Immigrant Asian Women Scholars in the United States.” **2024 Education & Health Research Hub Conference at George Mason University**, virtual, February.
- 2023 “Fit for good: Contested Social Class, Gender and Racial Contexts in the Weight Room.” **American Sociological Association Annual Conference**, Philadelphia, PA, August.
- 2023 “The Migration Old: exploring Chinese senior rural-urban population in the past 30 years with the age-period-cohort model.” **Population Association of America Applied Demographic Conference**, Annapolis, MD, February.
- 2022 “Asian Women in the Weight Room.” **Eastern Sociological Society 91st Annual Conference**, Boston, MA, March.
- 2021 “Her Voice: A Literary Analysis on Asian Women Scholars in American Academia.” **Chinese Sociological Association Annual Conference**, Chongqing, China, July.
- 2020 “Chinese Farmers’ Identity and Land Consciousness in an Urbanizing Era.” **Chinese Sociological Association Annual Conference**, virtual, June.
- 2019 “Socially Constructed Volunteering Experiences: a Qualitative Study among Undergraduate Students in Elite Universities in Shanghai” **Shanghai Sociological Association Annual Conference**, virtual, June.

HONORS AND AWARDS

- 2026 Wyatt Jones and James Schulz Dissertation Grant, **Brandeis University**, Waltham, MA
- *\$3,000 award aiming to cover dissertation expenses.*
- 2026 The Berkowitz Prize, **Sociology Department of Brandeis University**, Waltham, MA
- *\$600 prize for assistance in dissertation research in the name of the late Steven Berkowitz, PhD.*
- 2026 Roberta L. Lipson '76 and Ted Plafker Endowed Travel to China Fund, **Brandeis University**, Waltham, MA
- *\$2,500 award aiming to cover research or study expenses in China.*

2026	Heller School Student Enrichment Fund, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$3,000 award aiming to cover dissertation expenses.
2025	2025 Boston Writers of Color Literary Support Award, Grub Street Center for Creative Writing , Boston, MA - \$100 award to cover regular submission and contest fees, individual consultations, and enrollment in one-day seminars.
2024	2024 APPAM Equity and Inclusion Fellowship, Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM) , Washington, DC - \$1,389 stipend supporting participation in the 2024 APPAM conference and mentorship events.
2024	2024 Three Minute Thesis Competition First Place Prize (Humanities/Creative Arts/Social Sciences category), Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$1,000 prize for the first-place winner in the competition that challenges participants to explain their academic research clearly and engagingly within three minutes.
2024	Social Justice Internship Fellowship, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$2,956 fund supporting students who are interning for an organization that pursues social justice goals.
2024	Sagan Family Grant for Graduate Research, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$1,000 grant honoring one exceptional research project in women and gender studies.
2024	Provost Doctoral Research Award, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$1,000 award towards dissertation-related expenses.
2023	The GSAS PhD Research Award, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$1,000 award aiming to cover dissertation-related expenses
2022 summer and fall	The GSAS Connected PhD Funding, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - Supported by the Mellon Foundation, this grant totaling \$12,000 seeks to enrich professional development opportunities for doctoral students in the humanities and humanistic social sciences.
2022-2024	ASA Culture Section Editor Travel Fund, American Sociological Association - Totaling \$360 in support of the ASA conference attendance of the editors.
2022	Heller School Student Enrichment Fund, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$700 award aiming to cover pre-dissertation conference expenses.
2022	Summer Grant Writing Fellowship, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$300 award aiming to support grant writing.
2022	The Peter Conrad Award for Graduate Student Research, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - \$600 Sociology Department award to support one PhD student for pre-dissertation research.

2022	Spring 2022 GSAS Career Fellowship, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - <i>\$450 fellowship towards career development.</i>
2020	Scholarship of New Trajectories for the Ph.D. Seminar Series, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA - <i>\$400 fellowship towards career development.</i>
2018 and 2020	Undergraduate National Scholarship, Fudan University , Shanghai, China - <i>Totaling a \$1,000 award received by the student with the highest GPA in the department.</i>
2019	The Excellent Paper Award, Shanghai Sociological Association Annual Conference , Shanghai, China - <i>One undergraduate research paper was recognized in the annual meeting.</i>

RESEARCH POSITIONS HELD

Nov 2024 – Apr 2026	Retirement and Mobility Qualitative Researcher. Supervisor: Sylvia Stewart, Tatjana Meschede, Institute for Economic and Racial Equity at Brandeis University , Waltham, MA · Facilitate the data analysis of the longitudinal research on people's retirement financial plans.
Nov 2024 – Dec 2025	Disability Policy Qualitative Researcher. Supervisor: Anne Valentine and Lauren Smith, Lurie Institute for Disability Policy at Brandeis University , Waltham, MA · Conduct online landscape research on medical professionals' pedagogy concerning pregnant patients with disabilities.
May 2023 – Dec 2024	STEM Education and Gender Equality Researcher. Supervisor: Zora Haque, Marji Warfield, Institute for Economic and Racial Equity at Brandeis University , Waltham, MA · Collected interview data with 42 STEM educational program participants. · Transcribed and analyzed the interview data amounting to 60 hours.
Oct 2021 – May 2025	Quantitative Research Intern for <i>diversitydatakids.org</i> Project. Advisor: Clemens Noelke, Robert Ressler, Institute for Child, Youth and Family Policy at Brandeis University , Waltham, MA · Merged Child Opportunity Index data with Census datasets using Stata · Analyzed national demographic and violent-death data · Led a paper submitted to JAMA · Created maps for Child Opportunity Index mapping with R. · Conducted literature review based on ECLS-K data profile.
May 2022 – Dec 2022	Economic and Asset Researcher. Supervisor: Rebecca Loya and Madeline Smith-Gibbs, Institute for Economic and Racial Equity at Brandeis University , Waltham, MA · Drafted data collection instruments for interviews. · Documented and coded semi-structured interviews with 529 plan stakeholders.

- Co-wrote a 23-page policy evaluation report with the research team and Commonwealth. (Report name: *Increasing Access to Postsecondary Education Savings*)
- 2022 Summer Data Analyst and Modeler. Supervisor: Daniel J. Guhr, **Illuminate Consulting Group L.L.C.**; Haley Rosenfeld and Abigail Arnold, **Brandeis University**, Waltham, MA
- Retrieved, cleaned, merged, and analyzed academic and scientific research performance metrics from various data repositories and rankings, along with Brandeis data on doctoral programs and research funding.
- 2019 – 2021 Research assistant on a granted project on the social credit system in mainland China. Advisor: Cheris Shun-ching Chan, **University of Hong Kong**. Remote
- Reviewed mainstream newspaper archives from 1990 to 2019.
 - Recruited more than 20 interviewees.
 - Transcribed more than 20 recordings.
 - Wrote more than 10 brief reports to summarize the materials.

TEACHING AND MENTORSHIP

Independent Teaching Experience

- 2025 Summer Undergraduate 4-credit seminar: *Applied Research Methods*
- 2024 Fall *Divergent Identity: Unraveling China's Traditional and Modern Cultural Phenomena (5-class series with Brandeis Osher Lifelong Learning Institute)*
- 2024 Summer Undergraduate 4-credit seminar: *Observing the Social World: Doing Qualitative Sociology*

Teaching/Course Assistant Experience

- 2024 Spring *Introduction to International Relations*
- 2024 Spring
& 2023 Spring, Fall *Order and Change in Society*
- 2023 Spring *Health, Community and Society*
- 2022 and 2023 Fall *Basic Statistics for Social and Political Analysis*
- 2022 Fall *Sociology of Body and Health*
- 2022 Spring *Sociology of Education*
- 2021 Fall *Sociology of Reproduction*

Mentorship Experience

- 2025 Spring Writing Fellow, **Brandeis University Writing Center**, Waltham, MA
- Assisted the director in the administrative operations of the Writing Center.
 - Maintained the documentation of the administrative workflow.

2024 Fall	Graduate Writing Assistant, Brandeis University Student Support Services Program (TRIO) , Waltham, MA · Provided writing-related advice to first-generation college students from resource-restricted backgrounds.
2023-2024	Senior Writing Consultant, Brandeis University Writing Center , Waltham, MA · Managed the administrative operation of the University Writing Center. · Led regular workshops and graduate collaborative writing sessions.
2023-2024	Undergraduate Research Lead Mentor, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA · Managed the peer research mentor team consisting of 18 graduate and undergraduate students. · Organized 2 major recruitment events and 1 research networking event.
2022 Spring	Undergraduate Thesis Mentor, Brandeis University , Waltham, MA

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

2024-2026	Student Representative, American Sociological Association, Culture Section . Remote
2023-2024	Student Representative, American Sociological Association, Decision-making, Networks, and Society Section . Remote
2021-2026	Editorial Board Member, American Sociological Association, Sociology of Culture Section Newsletter . Remote <i>Editor-in-Chief</i> : Term 1 September to November 2021 Term 2 May to July 2022 Term 3 May to July 2023 Term 4 May to July 2024

SKILLS

Software	R, Stata, NVivo, ATLAS.ti, SPSS, ArcGIS, Python, Adobe Creative Suite
Languages	Mandarin (<i>native</i>), English (<i>professional</i>), Spanish (Duolingo level 23).

REFERENCES

Dr. Laura J. Miller (Committee Chair)
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